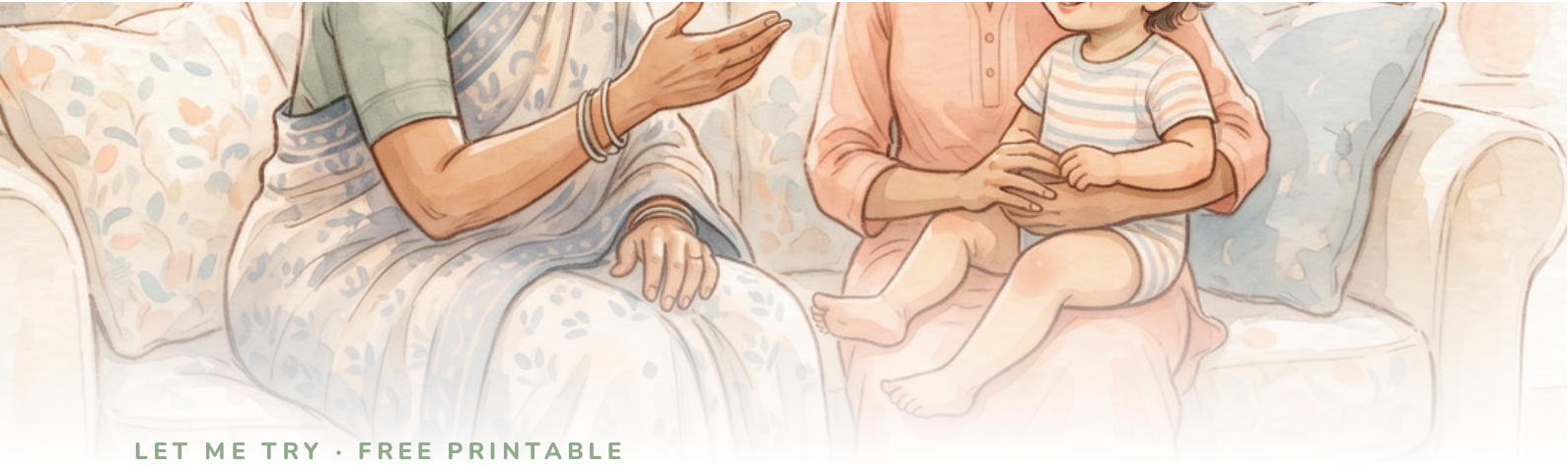


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What to Do Instead of Hitting

Calm discipline that works · Ages 2–4

Discipline means teaching. Children learn best from adults who are calm, clear and consistent. Here are tools that work in the real moments: hitting, throwing, refusing.

What the research found

- ○ A large review of studies found spanking linked to more aggression, more behaviour problems and poorer parent-child relationships, and not to better behaviour (Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor, 2016).
- ○ The American Academy of Pediatrics recommends against spanking and harsh verbal discipline (Sege & Siegel, 2018).

In the moment

- ○ Stop the action: “I won't let you hit.” Gently hold their hands.
- ○ Name the feeling: “You're really angry that it's time to go.”
- ○ Keep your voice low and slow. Your calm is contagious.
- ○ Move them to a quieter spot if needed.

After the storm

- ○ Reconnect with a hug or sitting together.
- ○ Teach what to do instead: “When you're angry, you can stamp your feet or squeeze a pillow.”
- ○ Repair together if something got broken or someone got hurt.

Prevent the next one

- ○ Predictable routines for meals, sleep and outings
- ○ Warnings before transitions: “Five more minutes, then shoes.”
- ○ Two choices instead of commands: “Red cup or blue cup?”

Talking with grandparents

Lead with respect: “You raised us with so much love. We're trying something new that the doctors recommend. Can you help us?” Ask them to call you in for discipline moments.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Gershoff, E. T., & Grogan-Kaylor, A. (2016). Spanking and child outcomes: Old controversies and new meta-analyses. Journal of Family Psychology, 30(4), 453–469.
Sege, R. D., Siegel, B. S., & AAP Council on Child Abuse and Neglect (2018). Effective discipline to raise healthy children. Pediatrics, 142(6).

General information, not medical advice.